

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Performance Conversation Planner

Prepare a fair, specific, forward-looking conversation about a performance concern — within proper HR process, never instead of it.

Purpose

When a team member is not meeting expectations, the kindest and most professional thing you can do is address it early, clearly and fairly — long before it becomes a formal process. This planner helps you prepare that conversation so it stays specific, evidence-based and focused on a way forward, rather than becoming vague, emotional or unfair. Its aim is that the person leaves knowing exactly what the concern is, what "good" looks like, and that you are invested in helping them get there.

Handled well and early, most performance concerns are resolved by a clear conversation and support — they never need to become formal at all. That early clarity is the whole point of this tool.

IMPORTANT — THIS IS A PLANNING AID, NOT HR OR LEGAL ADVICE

Serious or persistent performance and conduct matters must follow your organisation's HR policy and local employment law. Involve HR early. Do not use this planner to run a formal capability, disciplinary or dismissal process — it is a preparation aid for an early, informal, good-faith management conversation, and never a substitute for proper process, professional HR guidance or legal advice.

When to use it

- An early, informal conversation about a specific performance concern with someone who reports to you.
- When a pattern (not a one-off) has emerged and it is time to name it clearly and fairly.
- To prepare thoroughly so the conversation is calm, specific and kind rather than reactive.
- Before it escalates — early, honest conversations are what usually stop things reaching a formal stage.

Use the Coaching Plan instead when the person is meeting expectations and you are developing them further; use this when there is a genuine gap against expectations.

Instructions

1. Check yourself first: is this a genuine, evidenced pattern, or a one-off, a personality difference, or a gap you never actually made clear? If expectations were never set, that is on the manager, not the person.
2. Consider whether HR should be involved now. For anything serious or potentially formal, speak to HR before the conversation, not after.

3. Gather specific, factual examples — dates, situations, observable impact. Avoid characterisations and hearsay.
4. Clarify the expectation the person is not meeting, and be sure it was actually communicated.
5. Consider causes with an open mind: unclear expectations, a skills gap, a blocker, workload, or something personal you are unaware of.
6. Plan an opening that is direct, respectful and non-humiliating, and always in private.
7. Prepare to listen — there may be a cause you do not know. Come to understand, not only to deliver a verdict.
8. Define what good looks like, a realistic timeframe, and the support you will provide.
9. Plan to document the conversation and agreed actions factually, in line with your HR policy.

Worked example

Preparing an early, informal conversation with a QA engineer (an inherited team member, described here only in general terms) whose bug reports have repeatedly been too vague for developers to reproduce, causing rework and friction. This is a first, good-faith conversation, not a formal step.

Planner section	Worked entry
The concern (specific pattern)	Over the last several sprints, several defects were returned by developers as "cannot reproduce" because the reports lacked environment, steps and expected-vs-actual detail.
Evidence (factual, dated)	Three specific tickets in the last month reopened for missing reproduction steps; note the ticket references and what was missing in each.
Was the expectation clear?	Honestly, partly. There is a bug-report standard, but I never explicitly walked this person through it or checked their understanding. I will own that in the conversation.
Possible causes (open mind)	Skills/standard gap; unstable staging making reproduction genuinely hard; workload pressure causing rushed write-ups; unclear expectations from previous management.
My opening	"I'd like to talk about bug-report quality, because I think a bit of clarity here will make your work land better and reduce the back-and-forth. Can we look at a couple of recent examples together?"
What good looks like	Every defect reproducible from the report alone: environment, numbered steps, expected vs actual, evidence attached — to the team standard.
Support I will provide	Walk through the bug-report template together; pair on the next few reports; flag the staging instability separately as a real, shared blocker so it is not put on them unfairly.
Timeframe & review	Check in over the next two sprints in our 1:1s; review whether the pattern has shifted.
HR / documentation	Informal at this stage; note the conversation and agreed actions factually. If the pattern persists despite clear expectations and support, consult HR on next steps under policy.

Why this is fair: it leads with specific evidence rather than a character judgement, the manager openly owns the part where the expectation was not made clear, it stays genuinely open to causes (including an environment problem that is not the person's fault), and it pairs the concern with real support and a reasonable timeframe.

Blank reusable version

Planner section	Your entry
The concern (specific pattern, not a one-off)	
Evidence (factual, dated examples)	

Planner section	Your entry
Was the expectation clearly set and communicated?	
Possible causes (held with an open mind)	
My opening (direct, respectful, private)	
What good looks like	
Support I will provide	
Timeframe & review point	
HR involvement / documentation (per policy)	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Avoiding the conversation until frustration boils over and the feedback lands as an ambush. Using vague characterisations ("your attitude", "you're careless") instead of specific, dated facts. Assuming bad intent when the real cause is an unclear expectation, a blocker or a skills gap. Delivering a verdict without listening. Skipping HR on a matter that is already serious, or — the opposite error — reaching for formal process on a first, fixable issue. Failing to define what good looks like or to offer support. And never documenting, so there is no fair record of what was said and agreed.

How to interpret / use it well

- Separate the person from the behaviour throughout. You are addressing a specific gap, not passing judgement on their worth.
- Own your share honestly. If the expectation was never made explicit, say so — it builds trust and it is simply fair.
- Come curious. A genuine question about causes often surfaces a blocker or a personal situation that changes everything.
- Pair every concern with a clear standard, real support and a fair timeframe. Feedback without a path forward is just criticism.
- Know the line: the moment a matter is serious, persistent or potentially formal, it belongs in your HR policy and, where relevant, with legal guidance — not in a planner. This tool prepares the early conversation; it does not run the process.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Ask yourself before every performance conversation: "Did I make this expectation genuinely, explicitly clear — and did I check they understood it?" Surprisingly often the honest answer is no. Fixing that first is both the fairest thing to do and the fastest way to resolve the concern without anything ever needing to become formal.